boundary-related issues and increasingly highlighting the trade deficit. The last was effective insofar as the commitment to an FTA was finally abandoned.

As both India and China moved into a more confident era, their *inter se* relationship also witnessed additional issues of difference. This was visible in 2013 when the China–Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC) was first announced. Frictions in border areas continued to grow, though they remained below a certain threshold till 2020. China's blocking of UN listing of Pakistani terrorists involved in attacks on India became a matter of growing controversy. As the CPEC advanced, becoming part of the BRI, the violation of Indian sovereignty was deemed unacceptable. China's opposition to Indian membership of the NSG created another problem, hardly mitigated by its undermining of any efforts towards UN reform. And when it came to trade, promises of better market access looked less and less credible in the absence of delivery.

As the aggregate consequences of these developments began to be felt, the two nations sought at the SCO Summit in Astana in 2017 to limit damage by not allowing differences to become disputes. At the same time, they tried to explore the factors of stability in the relationship. Subsequent summits in Wuhan and Mamallapuram were largely in that direction. But far from mitigating differences, they have ended up witnessing a relationship under exceptional stress as a result of the events of 2020.

LESSONS FROM THE PAST

Given the gravity of its state now, it is natural that those who study the relationship will be particularly concerned where our ties are heading. It is hard to offer a definitive answer at this point in time. Whether it is our immediate concerns or more distant prospects, the fact is that the development of our ties can only be based on mutuality. Indeed, the three mutuals, mutual respect, mutual sensitivity and mutual interests, are its determining factors. There are discussions underway through various mechanisms on disengagement at the border areas. Many of the close-up deployments of the two sides in frictional areas have been resolved on the basis of equal and mutual security. But any that remain and the larger issue of de-escalation will continue to cast their shadow on bilateral cooperation.